Replace Invoice2Go

A practical playbook for trade shops

A practical playbook for trade shops leaving Invoice2Go.
Written for owners who still have jobs on the board this week.

Why shops leave Invoice2Go

Invoice2Go is good at invoices. Shops are not only invoicing. A painting or construction company also captures leads, writes estimates, takes deposits, schedules crews, and answers where a job stands at 7 a.m. When those steps live in texts, notebooks, and a separate invoicing app, money leaks.

Leaving a familiar tool is a migration of the work, not a branding project. This playbook is the sequence I use so the shop keeps billing while the new system comes up.

Draw the real path of a job

Sit with the owner and one estimator. Walk one recent job from first call to final payment. Write the objects, not the feelings:
Lead: who called, address, kind of work, photos if any.
Estimate: line items, tax, validity window, who approved.

Deposit: amount, method, date, what it unlocks.
Job: start window, crew, spec notes, change orders.
Invoice: remaining balance, extras, how the customer pays.
Closeout: photos, warranty note.

If a step only exists in someones head, it is still a step.

Freeze what you will not rebuild on day one

You do not need CRM theater. You need the path above. Out of scope until the path is live: marketing automation, a public customer portal you did not already promise, inventory unless missing stock stops jobs, GPS clocks if paper timesheets work.
Write the freeze on one page.

Export without folklore

Export customers, open invoices, and paid history. Keep PDFs of every open estimate.
Spreadsheet columns you actually need: customer name, phone, email, address, invoice number, amount, balance, status, date.
Duplicate customers now. Bad phones now. Print invoices with a remaining balance.

That list is the only migration that can hurt cash if you miss it.

Keep billing during the cutover

Pick a Friday. After that date, new estimates are born in the new system. Old open invoices may be collected in Invoice2Go until they hit zero, or you re-key the balances once. Mixing both for new work is how you double-bill.
Tell the crew: new jobs go in the new app. Do not start a job that is not in there.

What the first version must do

Create a lead from a phone call in under a minute.
Turn the lead into an estimate with line items.
Convert the estimate to a job.
Record a deposit.
Issue an invoice for the remainder.
Show the owner a list of jobs by status today.
If the phone cannot do those six, you are not ready to switch. A PWA beats a native app you will not maintain.

Payments and deposits

Record method (check, card, cash, Zelle) and who took it. Tie every payment to a job, not only to a customer. Deposits should change job status. Keep your card processor; the ops app stores the result. Never let a crew start a job with an unrecorded deposit unless the owner says so in the record.

Crew radio is not Slack

Field crews will not live in email. A simple job-scoped thread plus photo upload beats a second chat product. Keep it on the job record so six months later you can see why an extra coat was approved.

Training that lasts one morning

Owner, estimator, office person, one foreman. Run a fake job all the way through. Then run a real small job the same day. Leave a one-page cheat sheet: new lead, send estimate, take deposit, invoice.

If someone still opens Invoice2Go for new work after the cutover, watch them try before calling it a people problem.

A two-week sequence

Days 1-2: map the job path, export data, freeze scope.
Days 3-6: build the six actions, import customers.
Day 7: office dry run.
Days 8-10: live small jobs; new system is source of truth.
Days 11-12: collect remaining Invoice2Go balances; stop new use there.
Days 13-14: fix the three sharp edges people hit; write the operating note.

What I shipped

Pipeline CRM at https://pl.donhowardconstruction.com/ is a Next.js PWA for Don Howard Construction / Painting. It replaced Invoice2Go for leads, estimates, invoices, deposits and payments, jobs, and crew radio. Use it as a picture of the destination, not a claim that your shop is identical.

If you hire this out

Ask to see a live ops app, not a deck. Ask who answers when an invoice number is wrong. Ask for source code in your git. Prices on mauricegarcia.com are published starting numbers so you are not guessing.

Questions: hello@mauricegarcia.com

Office checklist the week you switch

Print the open-balance list.
Confirm every crew phone can add the PWA to the home screen.
Put the cheat sheet on the office wall.
Turn off new Invoice2Go documents after the cutover date.
Keep login to Invoice2Go for 30 days only to collect old balances.
Name one person who is allowed to create customers so duplicates stop.

Line items that survive a customer reading them

Write what the crew will do in words the homeowner already uses: rooms, coats, prep, haul-away.
Avoid internal SKU codes on the customer PDF.
Show deposit as its own line so it is obvious what was already paid.
Date the estimate and say how long it is good for.
If paint product is specified, name it. If it is allowance, say allowance.

Change orders

A change order is a new estimate line tied to the same job, not a text that disappears.
Who can approve: owner of the shop, not the newest helper on site.
Take a photo before extra work starts.
Do not invoice extras that were never written.

Photos

Before, during, after. Attach to the job, not to a camera roll that gets wiped.
A wet-wall photo is worth more than a paragraph in a dispute.

When not to leave Invoice2Go yet

If you have no one who will enter leads the same day, wait.
If the owner will not look at a daily list of open money, wait.
Software does not replace that habit. It only makes the habit cheaper.

After ninety days

Delete the unused columns you added in week one.

Archive jobs that are paid and older than a season.
Export a CSV and put it somewhere that is not only the laptop.

Naming the app

Call it something the crew will say out loud. Pipeline is a shop word. Do not name it after a framework.
The home-screen icon should be obvious at arm length.

Permissions

Office can see money. Crew can see the job they are on and radio. Owner sees everything.
Do not give every helper delete rights.

Backups

Nightly dump. Test a restore once before you need it.
If the app is hosted, know which account owns the project.

A note on Invoice2Go data quality

You will find jobs billed to a first name only.
You will find the same phone on three customers.
Fix the ones with open balances first. History can stay messy.

Closing

The point is not a prettier invoice. The point is one record of the job so the shop can answer money and schedule questions without a scavenger hunt.